



Jean Piaget's Cognitive Development Theory

Jean Piaget explained that children develop thinking abilities in stages as they interact with their environment. Learning happens through assimilation (fitting new ideas into what is known), accommodation (adjusting ideas to fit new information), and equilibration (balancing the two). ***He proposed four stages of cognitive development, each with unique features.***

1. **Sensorimotor Stage (0–2 years):** Children learn through senses and actions. They develop object permanence (knowing objects exist even when not seen). ***Example*** → A baby searching for a toy hidden under a blanket shows object permanence.
2. **Preoperational Stage (2–7 years):** Children develop language and symbolic thinking but are egocentric (see only their own view) and struggle with conservation. ***Example*** → A child believing a taller glass has more water than a shorter one, even if both hold the same amount.
3. **Concrete Operational Stage (7–11 years):** Children think logically about concrete objects, understand conservation, classification, and reversibility, but not abstract ideas. ***Example*** → A child realizing that $6 + 4 = 10$ and $10 - 4 = 6$ shows reversibility.
4. **Formal Operational Stage (12 years and above):** Adolescents develop abstract, logical, and hypothetical thinking. They can reason about moral issues and future possibilities. ***Example*** → A teenager discussing fairness or planning long-term goals demonstrates formal thought.

Erik Erikson's Psychosocial Theory of Development

Erik Erikson, a developmental psychologist, expanded on Freud's ideas and proposed the psychosocial theory of development. Unlike Freud, who emphasized psychosexual stages, Erikson focused on social and cultural influences across the entire lifespan. He believed personality develops through eight stages, each defined by a central conflict that must be resolved for healthy development. ***These stages are;***

1. **Trust vs. Mistrust (0–1 year):** Infants develop trust when caregivers provide consistent care and affection. ***Example*** → A baby whose mother responds to crying learns trust, while neglect leads to mistrust.
2. **Autonomy vs. Shame and Doubt (1–3 years):** Toddlers seek independence through activities like walking and toilet training. ***Example*** → A child encouraged to feed themselves develops autonomy, but over-criticism causes shame.
3. **Initiative vs. Guilt (3–6 years):** Children assert control through play and decision-making. ***Example*** → A child leading a game develops initiative, but being scolded for trying leads to guilt.
4. **Industry vs. Inferiority (6–12 years):** School-age children focus on learning and achievement. ***Example*** → Praise for good schoolwork builds industry, while repeated failure without support creates inferiority.
5. **Identity vs. Role Confusion (12–18 years):** Adolescents explore values and goals to form identity. ***Example*** → A teenager choosing a career path gains identity, while lack of direction leads to confusion.
6. **Intimacy vs. Isolation (18–40 years):** Young adults seek close, loving relationships. ***Example*** → Forming a committed

friendship or marriage shows intimacy, while avoidance causes isolation.

7. **Generativity vs. Stagnation (40–65 years):** Adults contribute to society through work, family, or service.

Example → Raising children or mentoring others shows generativity, while self-centered living causes stagnation.

8. **Integrity vs. Despair (65+ years):** Older adults reflect on their lives with satisfaction or regret. **Example** → An elderly person proud of their life feels integrity, while one full of regrets feels despair.

Sigmund Freud's Psychoanalytic Theory

Sigmund Freud, known as the father of psychoanalysis, developed the psychoanalytic theory to explain human personality, behaviour, and development. His theory emphasizes the role of unconscious processes, childhood experiences, and inner conflicts in shaping behaviour.

Freud described personality as consisting of three structures:

- **Id** – operates on the pleasure principle, seeking immediate satisfaction of desires. **Example:** A baby crying loudly for milk because it wants instant satisfaction, not caring about time or situation.
- **Ego** – works on the reality principle, mediating between id and the outside world. **Example** → A student feels hungry during class but waits until break time to eat.
- **Superego** – represents morality, conscience, and societal rules. **Example** → Someone finds money on the ground but returns it because “it’s the right thing to do.”

Freud also identified three levels of the mind:

- **Conscious** – thoughts and feelings we are aware of. **Example** → Right now, you are aware you are reading this text.
- **Preconscious** – memories that can be brought to awareness. **Example** → You are not currently thinking

of your best friend's birthday, but you can recall it if asked.

- **Unconscious** – hidden desires, fears, and conflicts influencing behaviour. **Example** → A person afraid of dogs without knowing why (hidden childhood trauma stored in the unconscious).

Another major aspect of Freud's theory is the psychosexual stages of development. He believed personality develops through five stages:

- **Oral (0–1 year)** – pleasure in sucking, biting. **Example** → Babies find pleasure in sucking and biting (e.g., breastfeeding, chewing toys).
- **Anal (1–3 years)** – toilet training, control. **Example** → A toddler enjoys toilet training and may develop habits of being very tidy or very messy.
- **Phallic (3–6 years)** – focus on genitals, Oedipus/Electra complex. **Example** → A child becomes attached to the opposite-sex parent (Oedipus/Electra complex).
- **Latency (6–12 years)** – sexual feelings dormant, focus on learning. **Example** → Children focus on school, hobbies, and friendships rather than sexual interests.
- **Genital (12+ years)** – mature sexual interests, relationships. **Example** → A teenager develops mature relationships and sexual attraction toward others.

NOTE 📌: To cope with inner conflicts and reduce anxiety, the ego uses defense mechanisms such as repression, denial, projection,

and displacement. These mechanisms help protect the individual but may also distort reality.